

Frida Chicaiza

May 1st

Media 150

Nancy Baker Cahill - Reflection

Throughout Nancy Baker Cahill's artist talk, I was constantly in awe of the kind of work that can be created and contributed to with modern technology. Before this talk, I knew very little about how media and technology could be integrated into the art world in such immersive and meaningful ways. What stood out most to me was her ability to combine physical experience with digital media through augmented reality, projection mapping, sound, and sensory interaction. Her projects demonstrated that art is much more than just sculpture and paint on a canvas and is no longer limited to something we only look at, but something we can experience through multiple senses and perspectives. One of the most interesting ideas Cahill discussed was the way AR/Augmented Reality exists as both invisible and visible at the same time. Without technology, these works cannot fully be seen, this fact only elevates the experience of this work as they still exist in the environment and influence the way people interact with space. This challenged my understanding of public art because it creates a form of collaboration between the artist, the audience, and technology itself. This to me was somewhat reminiscent of the performance pieces we focused on with "Cut Piece" by Yoko Ono, in which the audience is required to participate and blur the boundaries of the artists and audience, as the audience participates, they become the artist as well. The participatory audience aspect of AR art is seen most notably in "CENTO" which is a global participatory art project that combines the immersive video and AR to imagine the future hybrid creature designed to survive the sixth extinction and environmental collapse. The creature is made up of human, animal, microbial, marine, fungal, and machine parts. This project explores themes of synthetic biology, survival, and collective responsibility in the face of ecological crisis. One of the most important and

effective aspects of CENTO is its interactive AR component, where viewers around the world can participate in the creature's survival by adding virtual feathers through an app. Each feather gives the creature new properties, allowing it to evolve and grow stronger in real time through public participation. The idea of standing still while the artwork circles around you creates a completely different relationship between the audience and the piece. These same ecological themes continue throughout most of Nancy Baker Cahill's work and are especially visible in *Carbon 1*, where she explores ecological collapse and noise created by humans, machines, and technology. This piece layered together images of nature, industrial plants, animal skins, fire, and AI-generated botanical forms to create a fractured and unstable environment. As the film progresses, pixelated digital noise increasingly distorts the landscape until the world we know is completely erased. The fragmented visuals and chaotic feeling in *Carbon 1* and *Aftermath* reminded me of the animated documentary *Ryan* where the characters physically wear their emotional and psychological trauma on their fragmented bodies, with transparent faces and distorted features representing inner damage. Similarly, Cahill uses distortion, fragmentation, and deconstruction not just as a visual style, but as a way to communicate emotional, environmental, and societal collapse. Both works force viewers to confront uncomfortable realities that might otherwise be ignored.

Nancy Baker Cahill's talk expanded my understanding of what contemporary art can be. Her projects combine technology like AI and AR proving environmental awareness, collaboration, and sensory experience in ways that challenge traditional ideas of drawing and public art. I left the talk thinking more deeply about how digital tools like AR and VR can create effecting art pieces about environmentalism and participatory projects.

